Typography and Figures

Typography and Figures I

A newspaper's voice is its type. The engine registers, when present, the elegant text faces a real paper would license — Didot for the nameplate and display headlines, Georgia for body text, and a grotesque sans for kickers and labels — and falls back to ReportLab's always-available base-14 fonts when a face is missing. Registration is best-effort and never fatal: a checkout on a machine without the macOS supplemental fonts still renders a structurally identical paper in Times and Helvetica. Only the typography module names a font; every other module refers to three logical roles (display, body, sans, and their bold and italic variants), so a change of typeface touches one file.

A subtle lesson is recorded in the code: the bold weight inside a `.ttc` font collection is at a face-specific subfont index. Didot's collection orders its faces Regular, Italic, Bold; an early render produced *italic* headlines because the bold index was assumed to be one rather than two. The fix — and the comment that now guards it — came from inspecting the rendered raster, not the source.

Figures are generated in the monochrome idiom of newsprint by two means. Photo- graphic elements — the harbor, the lighthouse, the redwoods — are procedural grayscale scenes drawn with Pillow and passed through a forty-five-degree halftone screen, so they read as classic dot-screened newspaper photographs. Data graphics — a seven-day forecast, a tide curve, a Dungeness-crab landings bar chart — are rendered with Matplotlib in black and gray with serif labels, so they sit naturally

beside the type rather than fighting it. A missing image file degrades to a clearly labelled placeholder, never a crash.